

NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 13

The Flame Tempered by Water

Author

Adelbert Vervloet

Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus ≈ 75 min read aloud
Scenes	20
Version	2026-09-24 · EN-GB dossier after P1

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Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne

Episode 13 — The Flame Tempered by Water

Author Adelbert Vervloet

Logline

Moon-day at Mt. Silver. Red's files are not aphasia. Gold/Richter leads the Golbat, then asks. Combat: Perish Song, a borrowed Venusaur, Fearow withdrawn. Houndoom without a bark.

Place in the arc

Due: the gadgets; Mean Look; the Red task.

Paid: the tongue still there; the crop = a challenge; shared grief; the Houndoom choice.

Open: Houndoom in the lists; Venusaur / Blue; Red still on the slope.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Red · Gold/Richter	Village; path; combat
Oak	The files; mutism demystified
Lance (Champion)	Shared grief — ≠ Team Rocket executive
Blue	Pallet: Venusaur lent. Key to lock (≠ Green, Red's rival). she/her.
Green	Blue and Green; cold kindness; Red's imprecation
Houndoom / Fearow / Venusaur	Stance without bark; withdrawn; borrowed

Places (EN anchors)

Mt. Silver (village, slopes) · Oak's Lab (reminiscence) · Pallet Town (continual journey) · Viridian (Lance). Village signs: Swiss German. Alpine analogy (Zermatt, Matterhorn, Oberalpsee, Lago Lungin): once, off the map.

Moves / history

Pursuit: power 40 → 80 (recall, feints; doubled against flight). Stat drops are not cancelled by recall. They typically last through each battle. In alignment with physical integrity.

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Heading	Note
Blue	The series rival is Green. Here Blue lends Venusaur (Daisy / Leaf). One EN key from the reminiscence. Not both names in the same heading. she/her.
Screen notes	“the rest invisible”: outside the body. Espeon, Lanturn visible; the others off-frame.
Mt.Silver	A winter battle and the terrain of Mt. Silver in GSC and HGSS are implausible, following the real life. As a result, the battle takes place in autumn.

OST titles	Light in This Darkness, Thunder and Blood, Heavenly Father: pieces. Distinct narrative titles. Do not glue the piece-name to the place-line.
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Screen durations (excluding titles)

Nocturnal Day ≈ 2 min 25. Affinity ≈ 3 min 45. Compromise ≈ 2 min 40. Eve ≈ 1 min 55. Light ≈ 2 min 45. Thunder ≈ 3 min 20. Blue and Green ≈ 3. Kindness ≈ 2 min 50. Disillusionment ≈ 2 min 30. Youth ≈ 3 min 15. Farewell ≈ 3 min 30. Grief ≈ 2. Proximity ≈ 3. Heavenly Father ≈ 2 min 20–30. Journey ≈ 2 min 15. Wager ≈ 2 min + coda. Vivaldi ≈ 2–2 min 15. Choice ≈ 55 s–1 min 10.

BGM index — pieces (Nocturne OST)

Scene	Piece	Range
Camouflaged Intrigue	My Sister	01:54–02:07
Appearance / request	Light in This Darkness	00:25 · 00:51 · 01:21–02:00
The challenge	Thunder and Blood	entry · 00:26–
Skarmory / Lapras	Heavenly Father	01:51–04:03
Wager / ethic	Always	00:32–end
Houndoom choice	Annette's Journey	01:05–01:40 · 01:22–

BGM index — external piece

Vivaldi, L'Estate, presto — via Nocturne EP02 S01. Outside the named OST. Do not index as a trace.

BGM index — traces

Address only.

Scene	BGM
The Nocturnal Day	EP07 S01 17:36–19:00
Bureaucratic Affinity	EP01 S02 25:40–27:00
Bureaucratic Affinity	EP04 S01 22:05–22:41
The Camouflaged Intrigue	EP07 S01 13:43–16:00
The Time Compromise	EP04 S01 03:47–05:00
The Eve of the Turning Point	EP03 S01 16:54–17:29
Distant Proximity	EP05 S02 24:07–25:37
Distant Proximity	EP06 S01 09:00–09:58
Distant Proximity	EP04 S01 18:10–18:47
The Continual Journey	EP03 S02 25:00–26:30
The Continual Journey	EP07 S01 09:50–10:35
The Controversial Choice	EP03 S02 24:40–25:00

Order of scenes

1. The Nocturnal Day
2. Bureaucratic Affinity
3. The Camouflaged Intrigue
4. The Time Compromise
5. The Eve of the Turning Point
6. Light in This Darkness
7. Thunder and Blood
8. The Complexity of Ice
9. Blue and Green
10. Cold Kindness
11. A Trainer's Disillusionment
12. Stagnant Youth Is No Major Asset
13. Farewell to Childishness
14. Shared Grief
15. Distant Proximity
16. Heavenly Father
17. The Continual Journey
18. The Wager or the Ethic
19. Vivaldi L'Estate
20. The Controversial Choice

The scenes are inserted here. The close follows the body.

Scene — The Nocturnal Day

, Mt. Silver, *lower-altitude village* — *alpine summer light*

BGM 'EP07 S01 17:36 19:00'

The air was crisp. Refreshing, almost invigorating, and yet laden with a sombre solitude.

The daylight had a moonlike quality: a cold brightness, devoid of any real warmth, as if the sun itself had retreated a little.

Thin cascades trickled down the rock faces, stringy, gradual, little more than threads of water. In the distance, the mountain remained fully present, immense, without needing to reveal itself in its entirety. Like Zermatt, the approaches to the Matterhorn, St. Moritz, the areas around the Oberalp Pass or Lago Lunghin.

The village lay relatively low down. Not quite at the very bottom of the valley. A few low-rise buildings: the Pokémon Centre, two or three inns, a pharmacy, a shop. Basic amenities. Nothing in abundance. Just enough to meet the needs of passers-by and travellers who had no choice but to pass through here. The signs are in Swiss German.

Figures would occasionally cross the paths. But the place wasn't as busy as an ordinary place would be. Those who came here weren't 'quite normal'.

Inside the Centre, the artificial lighting was subdued.

Red was sitting at a console. He was charging devices, checking the computer, drafting reports and accessing Oak's research. His movements were precise and unhurried.

A nurse approached. Her voice was barely audible. She indicated that the Pokémon had recovered.

Red nodded slightly. He collected the Poké Balls with gentle, almost tender movements, but said nothing. Then he gathered his belongings.

A traveller was standing nearby. His attire was simple, basic. Certain features remained visible beneath the technical disguise. It was Gold/Richter.

He rose as Red made for the exit, and he followed at a safe, though imperfect, distance.

Red entered the hybrid establishment — part chemist's, part general shop.

He spoke briefly to the shop assistant. The movement of his lips was visible. He was still speaking. Not much. Concisely. Medicines. Antidotes.

Around him, the traveller paused, then approached more stealthily.

Gold/Richter said nothing. His eyes were heavy. A deep-seated, confirmed melancholy, more poignant than when he'd seen him on a computer screen.

Red stepped back out. The distance remained.

Outside, the summer light still looked like night. The air remained crisp, and the solitude, gloomy.

End of scene

Scene — Bureaucratic Affinity

Oak's laboratory. A *spring evening* — a *flashback*

The light was dim. The switched-off screens allowed shadows to settle between the shelves. Oak handed Gold/Richter a stack of printed files.

Gold/Richter took them. The first few lines eluded him for a moment. The wording was clear, but more terse than he had expected.

'Why these files...?'

"Red's creations."

Gold/Richter looked up. His bewilderment was brief, but distinct.

Oak continued, without raising his voice:

"I believe this might ease one of your most deeply ingrained reservations."

Gold/Richter leafed through them again.

"These files are recent...?"

"Red keeps reporting back to me. Scientifically. To justify his funding. Like a never-ending research project. But the reports remain narrower in scope than the actual extent of his travels."

A silence.

Oak added:

"Access to Mt. Silver is restricted. Without authorisation. Some have gone there clandestinely. To dethrone him. In vain.

The rumours are unanimous: he's supposedly lost the power of speech.

However... that's not quite right."

Gold/Richter pored over the pages once more. This time, it was not the data he sought. It was the wording. The structure of the sentences. The rhythm.

Oak looked at him.

BGM: "EP01 S02 25:40–27:00"

'Mutism. Aphasia. These are watered-down projections. Casual observations. Pretexts for their lack of discipline...

His language remains functional. Even with depth. For analysis. For more sophisticated strategies.

He remains in contact with others. But more superficially.

A typical symptom: someone is still there, but lacking anything in common. Few points of convergence. Like a hollow or incomplete shell.

The rhythm. The frequency. Something no longer fits.'

Gold/Richter closed the files for a moment.

"Why are you confiding this in me...? Isn't this rather a matter of medical confidentiality...?"

Oak replied without beating about the bush:

"Professional respect. If you're a neurologist... you'll recognise these symptoms. Because you've experienced almost identical problems yourself."

Gold/Richter was taken aback. The memory of his own history came flooding back without warning. The frustration of having been pathologised flashed across his face.

Oak continued, more calmly:

BGM "EP04 S01 22:05–22:41"

"It reminds me of your epithet. Red used to share things with me too, back then. But he wasn't as bureaucratic as you.

Your bureaucracy stems from the same trauma as his. Since you're caught up in this scourge.

To demystify it, you'd be better off trusting your own experiences... if you fear that Red is a spectre rather than a living being."

He made no attempt to sugar-coat it. Time was somewhat of a factor. He agreed to reopen the area.

Gold/Richter looked down at the files.

'... Thank you for making an exception. It's just... I cannot defeat him by debate alone.'

Oak looked him straight in the eye.

"You're not planning to free him solely by the result of a battle, are you...?"

Then, in a lower voice, almost to himself:

"If it works... luck would be on your side. No doubt."

He turned his head towards the window. For a moment, he searched the spring night for more peaceful solutions.

Gold/Richter remained standing, the files in his hands, hesitant, wavering, not yet knowing what form the next steps would take.

End of scene

Scene — The Camouflaged Intrigue

Mt. Silver Hillside — *the cusp of summer and autumn, 6–7 pm*

The path was rarely trodden. Dead leaves lay in an uneven layer. Moss covered the stones. The air already had that bite of September. A few patches of snow lingered in the hollows.

Red was making his way down. Pikachu was at his side.

BGM: 'EP07 S01 13:43–16:00'

A sudden clamour echoed through the shadows.

They halted. Their alertness was keen. They braced themselves.

The Golbat burst from the darkness without hesitation, without pretence. It took full advantage of everything: the time of day, the slope, the relative darkness.

Wing Attack. Vehement, aimed at Pikachu — but it was merely a feint.

Pikachu responded. **Thunderbolt.**

The preparation had been insufficient. The lingering snow, the Golbat's unusual agility: the bolt was dodged.

Golbat followed up. **Air Cutter.** Less a decisive blow than a precise diversion. It pushed Pikachu towards a chosen spot.

Then the ghostly light rose.

Confuse Ray.

Pikachu narrowly missed the path. Golbat combined the two attacks with an almost vampiric, predatory flair.

Red and Pikachu retreated.

BGM 'EP07 S01 13:43–16:00' 00:38

The path remained visible: an almost full moon, a few scattered streetlamps. Cold, patchy light—enough to make their way without being abundant.

They reached the edge of a pond connected to a river. Red recalled Pikachu and sent Lapras into the water.

As they moved, a hunch began to take shape. Too many coincidences. And what's more: that Golbat seemed to have *led* them towards the water. As if it wanted to test what a Water-type Pokémon was truly capable of.

BGM 'EP07 S01 13:43–16:00' 00:57–

The same Golbat reappeared.

Air Cutter at Lapras. Lapras used water to dodge and countered with **Ice Beam**.

Golbat dodged with a tenacity not typical of the local inhabitants.

Then it fired another **Confuse Ray**, this time in a circular pattern. Not to strike immediately. To besiege. To encircle.

The ghostly reflection skimmed across the water's surface. Golbat traced a circle around Lapras and Red like a calculating, zealous, patient raven.

BGM "EP07 S01 13:43–16:00" 01:17–

Red drew the Pokédex.

The level displayed stopped him in his tracks. Ostensibly higher than anything else living here.

A brief daze. Then realisation: some Golbat, some Misdreavus, were not wild. Even if their abilities remained latent.

In the more secluded corners, a human figure watched. No sadism. Reluctance. Causticity. Guilt. A melancholic, almost awestruck gaze.

Gold/Richter.

Red could not pinpoint him.

BGM 'EP07 S01 13:43–16:00' 01:32–

He gave the order. Lapras prepared **Psychic** — seeking an almost immediate effect, a sense of stability.

Golbat read the attentional allocation. This time, the **Confuse Ray** was direct. Blinding. Without distraction.

Lapras was thrown into confusion. The execution of Psychic was interrupted.

Red was struck by the anomaly: a Pokémon capable of acting with such precision without any apparent verbal command.

BGM 'EP07 S01 13:43–16:00' 01:54–

Golbat let out a **Screech**.

The target did not seem to be limited to Lapras. The scope of the cry, its austere and clinical frenzy, was also intended to prevent Lapras from focusing solely on itself.

BGM 'My Sister' 01:54–02:07

Red recognised the combination: Screech plus Confuse Ray. Defence drop. Confusion.

Somebody was watching him. Somebody was intercepting him.

Golbat lunged forward.

Wing Attack. Made all the more forceful by the lowered defence.

The impact on the target was not clearly visible; only the increased force was noticeable.

The figure in the shadows did not move.

The path behind them remained bathed in the dim light of the moon and the streetlamps.

End of BGM 'My Sister' -02:07

End of scene

Scene — The Time Compromise

Mt. Silver Room near the inn — early autumn light

The room was simple. Dark wood, understated lighting, a window open to the air, which was already crisp.

Gold/Richter sat at the computer. Columns of figures. Damage projections. Stats — his own, Red's. Only fragments of them were visible.

He was working earnestly. Neither utter pessimism nor complete optimism.

He drew in a deep breath. He refused to let himself be overwhelmed by the sheer numerical disadvantage. He sought to reconcile what the data was telling him with what the team, out on the ground, should still be capable of doing.

He carried on for a moment, feeling calmer.

Then he put everything on hold. He browsed to other pages.

The weather report appeared. The omens were not good. Winter was approaching. The conditions would be more precarious than simply facing Red.

His gaze grew more pensive. More serious.

He shut down the computer. Tried to brush aside his worries. They lingered, like a residue.

Outside lay the mountain village. There was no widespread snow yet. The air was crisp.

In the distance, Gold/Richter made out a figure. Red. He was walking away in the exact opposite direction.

"EP04 S01 03:47–05:00"

Gold/Richter did not follow him. He scanned his surroundings.

A narrow, vertical waterfall, almost motionless in the distance. Natural watercourses cascading down the rock faces. High-altitude meadows, wooden roofs, mountain ridges he'd never looked at closely before.

Mt. Silver was visible from his hometown. Always. But this was the first time he'd reached it.

It was almost a point of pride for his people. A patriotic sentiment, discreet and unassuming.

He lingered for a moment in this sense of equanimity.

Then something became clearer. Red carried a kind of imprecation. But the mountain itself was not to blame. It offered him a neutral refuge from the full consequences of that burden.

A natural generosity.

Gold/Richter bowed his head slightly. A gesture of deference to nature — or to that which, within it, took the place of divinity.

He made his way to a terrace facing Johto.

There, the view opened up. Far away. Ecruteak. New Bark Town.

He did not regard it as one regards an inevitable fate. He knew that his reason, his data, his conviction were not entirely independent of this support.

Nor were they entirely free from a sense of supplication.

His eyes lingered for a long time on the horizon.

Neutral. Somber. Serene.

Like a prayer.

End of scene

Scene — The eve of the turning point

Mt. Silver Inn, 2–3 am — *autumnal air*

The room was cold. Gold/Richter had hardly slept. His sleep remained fitful.

A faint rustling sound roused him from bed. He got up silently and opened the door cautiously.

It was Red.

Gold/Richter waited a second, then followed him. Keeping a safe distance. Not a sound out of place.

In the main hall, Red released his Pokémon. Lapras. Charizard. Pikachu. Venusaur. Espeon (the rest were invisible due to the screen). He handed out the rations methodically, without rushing. Then he went to fetch his own.

Gold/Richter, from the shadows of the corridor, understood his intention. He returned to his room without a word.

EP03 S01 16:54–17:29"

He, in turn, released those that could fit into the confined space. Fearow. Skarmory. Lanturn (the rest were invisible on screen). He handed out the rations hastily.

Meanwhile, on the other side of the partition:

Red was eating at his usual pace. So were his Pokémon. There was no rush.

Gold/Richter chewed. His rhythm was erratic. Fluctuating. Every mouthful carried the worry of the outcome that had not yet come to pass. Less hope. More pressure.

Red had already returned to his room. He was brushing his teeth as if it were an ordinary, everyday, natural gesture.

Gold/Richter, having eaten too quickly, tried to do the same. He tried hard to maintain a normal pace. Certain subtle gestures betrayed his anxiety.

Outside the inn. The air was crisp. Around three o'clock.

Red went out. Minimal kit. He was already making his way up the footpath leading towards the upper part of the mountain.

Gold/Richter came out in turn. Quietly.

His expression remained unsettled. His distress, despite his efforts to contain it, was clearly visible in the dim light.

End of scene

Scene — Light in This Darkness

, Mt. Silver *Slightly higher slopes — 3–4 hours*

The snow was fine. It covered the stones without obscuring them. The paths remained passable, marked by old tracks and the wind's imprint.

All around them, the slope opened out like the flanks near Lago Lunghin: short, already scorched grass, grey boulders mottled with lichen, narrow streams trickling down between the stones in cold rivulets. Higher up, patches of snow clung to the hollows. Further down, the valley widened in the uncertain moonlight.

Red was climbing. Pikachu moved alongside him, its paws sinking into the thin layer of snow. The effort was real, without any exaggeration. Just the slope, the cold stinging his lungs, and that still-formless anxiety that had roused him from sleep too soon.

They reached a point where the water became more abundant — almost at the source of a network of streams. The water ran clear between the flat rocks, reflecting the moonlight intermittently.

Red stopped. He looked back. The slopes descended in successive terraces, cut through by torrents, scree slopes and dark patches of stunted vegetation. There was something unusual and stark about the landscape in the cold light.

BGM: 'Light in This Darkness' 00:25–

Then came the flapping of wings.

Multiple. Steady. Not a swarm.

Red and Pikachu froze.

Several Golbat emerged from the shadows along the rocks. They approached, then maintained a precise distance. No charge. No opening for an attack.

They remained there, suspended in the cold air, more like markers than attackers.

Red noted the discrepancy. This was not the behaviour of creatures at these altitudes.

He made a brief gesture towards Pikachu — low, calm — to hold back any reaction. No need for unnecessary bloodshed on this still-pristine snow.

The air thickened. Not hostile. Enigmatic.

BGM: 'Light in This Darkness' 00:51-

A footstep echoed further down, where the moonlight struck a patch of lighter-coloured rock.

A young man stepped out of the shadows.

Gold/Richter.

His footsteps were enough. Pikachu tensed. Red stared at him.

His demeanour was composed. His shoulders were steady. His face, bathed in moonlight, showed a confidence that failed quite to conceal the underlying tension.

The Golbat moved towards him, hovering above at a safe distance, like discreet satellites.

Gold/Richter took another step forward. Then, without haste, he drew his hunting crop.

BGM: 'Light in This Darkness' 01:21–02:00

He raised it. He traced a sharp, almost ritualistic circle in the air. The movement was precise, without any flourish.

The Golbat around him moved away. They did not return.

Red stood motionless.

The question hung in the air for a moment. Master? A recognised threat? Merely a theatrical gesture?

Then another interpretation emerged, a more direct one, the kind that only trainers recognise without words.

It was not an ambush. It was a request. Made with a certain dignity.

Red did not object.

He let what followed unfold in the cold.

End of scene

Scene — Thunder and Blood

Mt. Silver *High-altitude slopes — fine snow, 3–4 hours*

BGM 'Thunder and Blood'

The distance between them remained unchanged. Red and Gold/Richter looked at each other. No words. Just their breath visible in the cold, the weight of their bodies shifting slightly on the snow, the subtle adjustments of their shoulders.

Gold/Richter raised his hand. He whistled.

BGM 'Thunder and Blood' 00:26–

Fearow emerged from behind him. Slowly at first. Without any forced element of surprise. As if the integrity of the challenge still demanded that pause.

Red took note of the choice. Pikachu, however, did not wait.

Thunderbolt.

Fearow stepped aside. A slight increase in speed. Agility, held back. He watched.

Then he lunged.

Pikachu braced for impact. It did not come. Fearow flew past, close enough to feel the rush of air, but not close enough to make contact.

At a brief gesture from Red, Pikachu deployed **Double Team**. The clones scattered. Fearow barely lost track of them — Keen Eye, and something else, a mastery already in place.

Aerial Ace. One of the clones vanished.

Red raised his fingers slightly. Pikachu switched to **Quick Attack**. Fearow kept its distance—risky, but manageable.

Pikachu accelerated again. At the very last moment, its body spun round — **Iron Tail**.

Fearow sped up even further. Agility. The blow merely grazed its feathers.

Red took note. This Fearow moved through the snow with an ease that was not typical of an ordinary first encounter.

The wind picked up for a moment. Fine snow swirled, then settled again.

Pikachu fired off another **Thunderbolt**. Dodged.

Fearow responded. **Mirror Move**. The same bolt of lightning shot out again. Pikachu was struck at an angle. The discharge remained moderate — same type, limited special attack — but it added to the damage already inflicted.

Pikachu aimed wider. The bolt spread out, almost desperately.

Fearow soared upwards. Agility at maximum. It dodged even the most convoluted trajectory.

Pikachu showed signs of fatigue from pushing itself too hard. Fearow took advantage. Several **Mirror Moves** in quick succession. The shocks piled up.

Red could clearly see that Fearow was still refusing direct contact. No head-on counterattack. Just keeping his distance and mirroring moves.

Fearow slowed down slightly, whilst retaining its speed advantage. It watched.

Red exchanged a glance with Pikachu. The type advantage no longer carried much weight in the face of this acceleration.

Gold/Richter read the gesture. Minimal communication. Fearow closed the gap by a barely perceptible margin.

Red raised his hand. Recall.

BGM ‘Thunder and Blood’ 02:18–

The light flared up.

Gold/Richter and Fearow treated the opening as a gamble. Fearow surged forward at top speed.
Pursuit.

The strike was clinical. Brutal. In the snow.

The Poké Ball landed in Red’s palm.

The end of the BGM ‘Thunder and Blood’

Fearow made contact. And, in that very instant, paralysis seized him. Static. Its speed plummeted, despite everything Agility had built up.

A sense of relief washed over Gold/Richter and Fearow. Partial. Not complete.

Silence returned.

Red stood motionless for a few seconds. He pondered.

Then his voice rose, low, almost matter-of-fact.

“How phenomenal this is...”

Gold/Richter and Fearow froze at the abrupt change in tone.

Red continued, without raising his voice:

“A Trainer unlike any we’ve ever seen... whose Pokémon adapts to the snow... so skilfully... This is no... ordinary sight...”

Gold/Richter did not reply. A sense of foreboding flashed across his face — as if he could already hear the suspicions that were bound to follow.

End of scene

Scene — The Complexity of Ice

Reminiscence: *Training — environment altered by Hail*

The summer light still hung in the air, but altered. Fine sleet. A dry wind. The ground was already slippery beneath a thin layer that was no longer quite rain and not yet lasting snow.

In the middle of the exercise. Lapras facing Skarmory. No quest for a winner. Merely acclimatisation to a temporary hostility.

Lapras moved with a weighty ease. Every move Skarmory made cost more than it should have. Gold/Richter could sense it in the way the bird held back its trajectories, in the fatigue that set in all too quickly.

Lapras attempted a move that cut through the air. The outcome was unclear.

Then a lull.

Training was suspended. Hail remained.

Gold/Richter caught his breath. Still too focused. Not quite back to a normal rhythm.

Lorelei, for her part, remained equanimous. Calm. Yet not detached. She had been watching.

‘...To tell the truth, I don’t have much to teach you.’

Gold/Richter raised his head slightly.

“That’s more than enough.”

He tried to regain his rhythm. Without quite succeeding.

Lorelei paused for a moment.

BGM ‘EP01 S01 14:37–16:34’

“I’m sorry for living up to my image... for being so cold.”

Gold/Richter replied flatly:

“Professional detachment. Yes.”

A very faint smile flitted across Lorelei’s face. Detached. Almost self-deprecating.

She continued:

“You’ll be facing the supreme trainer. Not an antagonist. But the fight won’t unfold in the conventional way.”

The sleet continued to fall, fine and steady.

“Mt. Silver...” she said. “The extreme environment will become a major threat. I don’t think you’ll make it out before autumn. You’ll have to adapt to it. Ideally, not in the middle of winter.”

Gold/Richter fell silent for a second.

“But could I acclimatise to it as well as Red...? He adapted to it for a while. Would that training... be enough?”

Lorelei shook her head ever so slightly.

“Certainly not. But it’s far better than doing without it.

From what people say, many have lost to him. The main reason was the climate. His skill, too. That would be an asset. A decisive one, no doubt.”

Gold/Richter thought for several seconds. He was still a little out of breath.

“...I didn’t plan this challenge to show off. I was simply struggling to find someone to turn to for these preparations. And you came along.

Your help is invaluable. Kind. I'm grateful to you."

A longer pause.

"It's hardly realistic to expect your kindness to be repaid..." he said. "But in Lance's name... I once gave up on aiming for the League."

Lorelei gazed for a moment at the fine hail.

"The reason for my stepping down... is that the new generation needs warmth more than coldness like mine."

Gold/Richter replied:

"...Coldness isn't always harmful. Is it?"

Lorelei did not reply straight away.

"My element, ice, embodies a more diverse concept than Pryce's."

She let her gaze wander over the transformed surroundings.

"Mt. Silver is a beautiful place. Its beauty is undeniable. But Red is forced to find a place where it snows frequently... I hardly think it's because he likes ice or snow."

A silence fell. She continued:

"In that case, snow and ice represent complexity. If we want to get him out, we can't ignore them. We have to face them and untangle them... just as we face life."

She tilted her face slightly towards him.

"Not all young people are prepared to confront it so hastily. Not at that level."

'But you're about to do just that, aren't you?'

Gold/Richter gave the question his full attention.

It went beyond what he had prepared for.

He could not come up with an immediate answer.

End of scene

Scene — Blue and Green

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, shortly after Pikachu's rappel*

BGM 'EP04 S02 00:09–02:25'

The snow was falling more lightly. Fearow was still hovering in the air, slowed down. Gold/Richter noted this slowing and deduced paralysis. He didn't quite conceal his caution. Red watched him without speaking.

A brief silence fell.

Red spoke first, in a low, almost matter-of-fact voice:

“Generally speaking... contenders don’t even survive the climax. Some were quite capable, but the snow diluted everything. You, however, stand out.”

Gold/Richter replied with a calmness that was a little too controlled:

“When facing the supreme Trainer, preparations are... imperative.”

His tone slipped despite himself. He was relieved that Red was speaking again, but the tension did not ease.

Red simply asked:

“Preparations... which ones?”

He threw a Poké Ball. Lapras appeared.

Gold/Richter and Fearow assumed their battle stances once more. Fearow’s paralysis was already clouding Gold/Richter’s judgement; he could no longer anticipate his opponent’s moves clearly. Fearow tried to move away to avoid the ice attacks. Red made a subtle gesture. Gold/Richter read it — too late. Red noted that the gesture had been understood.

Lapras unleashed Psychic, which hit almost instantly from a distance. Fearow suffered the mental shock. By reflex, it reflected the attack back using Mirror Move. The damage was distinctly lopsided. Gold/Richter recalled Fearow immediately. The Poké Ball returned to his palm.

Red continued, without raising his voice:

‘You’re even capable of deciphering some of my gestures to communicate with my Pokémon...’

The atmosphere shifted.

“All that build-up... a bit over the top.”

A pause.

“I’d had the feeling I’d been followed for months. So it was you. Am I wrong?”

Guilt was building up inside Gold/Richter. He did not reply.

Red continued:

“Some Golbat... some Misdreavus... weren’t wild. They were under your command. That’s the answer.”

Gold/Richter lowered his eyelashes slightly. Red saw it. A wry smile flitted across his face.

“I’m not accusing you of anything. You didn’t cheat. It’s just... your approach is extraordinarily skilful. Come to think of it... your tactics are rather reminiscent of a Team Rocket member. Unspectacular, but tenacious.”

The comparison struck Gold/Richter like a tonne of bricks, and a distinct sense of remorse washed over him.

Red continued:

“Polishing the throne, the crown... that is commendable. You have put your heart into it. I would like your efforts to be reciprocated.”

Gold/Richter, after a silence:

“How do the throne and the crown feel...?”

Red said:

“Formless. Heavy. Too heavy. I’d just like someone to succeed me. That would lighten the load. The problem isn’t being obsessed with them. It’s being able to cope with them.”

Gold/Richter’s expression darkened.

Red added, almost as a cold quip:

“It is mad that Team Rocket would take their revenge on me by dethroning me...”

BGM ‘Vampire Messiah’ 00:00–00:44

Unbeknownst to Red, Gold/Richter took out two badges and held them up. Red looked at them. The first one — blue, Misty’s — struck him. A sense of nostalgia without any images welled up, just a sensation, a brief surge of energy. He did not pull the badge out. He brushed against it through the coat, just enough to feel it, without removing it entirely. The warmth remained inside, contained, and isolated him for a moment from the words. His gaze remained fixed on it.

Then he scrutinised the second one, the green one. No loathing, even though it was linked to Giovanni. Just a stray memory, almost anonymous.

Red asked:

‘The other one... whose is it? Who became that Gym Leader...?’

Gold/Richter replied, more quietly:

“...Green.”

Red did not grasp at once. He could not, or would not, accept it at once.

End of scene

Scene — Cold Kindness

Viridian — springtime daylight

The setting was crisp, almost too crisp. You could see the town, the trees, the ordinary spring light, and yet everything seemed a notch removed, as if only the conversation truly remained.

Gold/Richter spoke first, still reeling from his visit to Red’s house:

‘So Red didn’t take his Earth Badge with him...?’

Green took out the badge. He looked at it for a moment, unhurriedly, with a worn-out bitterness.

“He needed it, for a while. Not for a long time now.”

He turned it slightly between his fingers.

"He tortured it rather than validating it. He must not have managed to get all his Pokémon to obey him. If it hadn't been for me... he'd have got rid of it by now."

Gold/Richter did not reply. He simply mulled over in silence what he knew about Green's predecessor.

Green looked up.

BGM "EP04 S02 18:10–19:00"

"Your story is interesting. You've become the person you never wanted to be. But that's not quite right."

Gold/Richter barely furrowed his brow.

"What do you mean...?"

"You almost became what you thought you wanted to be. But the nuance, the real twist, is that you thought you'd become what you hadn't wanted to be."

Gold/Richter's eyes widened slightly as a fragment of that surgical truth sank in. Green continued, his voice more subdued:

"It was the same for me. I, too, thought I wanted to become the most powerful of fools... Then that tragedy struck at Red's, because of my own calculations."

"Did he become that...? Wasn't he reluctant..."

"He became what he'd never wanted to be. A darker version of himself."

Gold/Richter fully grasped the scale of the disaster. A sense of remorse settled over the silence of the springtime square. Green continued after a pause:

"He resisted slipping into the same trap as my predecessor. But he could not escape the other fate: being the strongest. That is one of his imprecations."

He paused for a moment, then quoted, almost without inflection, as if reading from an official report:

"'I wish I could say that I am doing my utmost to save you... because I regard you as my brother. But I cannot.'"

He added, in an even quieter voice:

"You can imagine just how cold his words were when he said that. But in reality... it was his only way of being kind."

Gold/Richter took a moment to let the words sink in.

"... A kindness that involves becoming what one has never liked being... to protect others..."

Green looked him straight in the eye:

"Were you pretending...?"

Gold/Richter nodded. No words. Just the silent admission of what he had already done for others.

Green tilted his head slightly, as if he recognised the pattern.

BGM: 'My Sister' 00:00–00:30

"That is the extent of his intelligence. He sacrifices himself. But to save others, he needs to protect himself... to set boundaries in the relationship. Because love alone was not enough, not even brotherly love. Certain cold-hearted decisions are made, usually out of cruelty. Occasionally out of an unusual, yet solitary, kindness."

Gold/Richter pressed on, his voice catching:

"He didn't really treat you like that... did he?"

'...Probably back then.'

"But for you...?"

Green looked away for a moment towards the trees of Viridian, searching for the most tactful way to put it:

"...It's not something we can simply choose. He did so much for me, even if he pretended to reject it. Those feelings take root. It's... simply inevitable."

Gold/Richter paused to think. There was no reply. The air in Viridian remained clear and spring-like, and yet seemed cut off from everything else.

End of scene

Scene — A Trainer's Disillusionment

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 3–4 hours*

The Pokédex appeared first.

Gold/Richter held it open in his palm and presented it without fanfare. Red looked at it. The astonishment was palpable, almost physical. His successor was already there, standing before him, fully trained, and had come from Johto.

Gold/Richter spoke first, seriously, without pride:

'I am one of your successors. But from Johto.'

Red turned his gaze slightly towards the unseen panorama behind the curtain of snow and night. A fleeting sense of exotic nostalgia washed over him.

He replied simply:

"...All right."

The veiled hostility and defensive sarcasm had faded. Some mistrust remained, but a sense of wonder prevailed. Gold/Richter read the tentative acceptance and put away his Pokédex. Their scarves fluttered in the snowy air.

Gold/Richter continued, in a lower voice:

"I saw that your Earth Badge was still at home... I suppose you must have given it up..."

Red fell silent. No reproachful glance.

Gold/Richter continued:

"I can't begin to imagine the challenges you must have faced as my predecessor. Nor the weight of that badge. I had a naïve dream. Perhaps I admired that Gym Leader... and I was frustrated by it. But you were different. So I can't imagine those feelings from your perspective..."

Red finally spoke:

"It was a tangled mess even for me, as far as Giovanni was concerned."

Gold/Richter's interest was piqued. Red looked at his hands for a moment.

BGM "EP04 S01 22:05–22:41"

"The strongest Gym Leader in Kanto was the head of a criminal syndicate. You might think it all came from outside. But no. He was already on the inside. A betrayal."

Silence fell.

"I've never admired Giovanni," said Red. "Nor any of those who hold such titles — apart from Professor Oak. So I don't know how the Trainers who aspire to them feel. Nor how much it breaks them when their ideal crumbles."

His tone was detached, almost precocious. It took Gold/Richter by surprise, and he asked:

"Does that badge still weigh so heavily on you...?"

Red let out a brief, joyless chuckle.

"The badge of a man who nearly killed me—or killed my loved ones—just to hurt me? No. I've no desire to keep that."

Further down:

"Giovanni unsettles me. I no longer know if adults can really sink that low... or if it's just those who chase after power. Or me. Who took the title back from Green in a way I still can't bring myself to accept."

Gold/Richter's mood darkened. His expressions gave him away.

Red almost added:

"Never mind. At least, without this badge, I've nipped a risk in the bud. The risk of becoming like him."

He spoke as if he were making excuses for Gold/Richter's age, even though he himself was still young.

After a while, Red asked:

"Why did Green take on this role, exactly?"

Gold/Richter asked pointedly:

"You didn't know...? Even with your limited contacts?"

Red recalled:

"It slipped my mind. I don't follow the news. I only use my computer to send my reports to the Professor."

Then, more curtly, to dispel the awkwardness:

"The Supreme Badge is worth more than the title of Champion, is that it?"

Gold/Richter could not shake off his unease, even though he knew it was not a serious matter.

He then spoke, almost awkwardly:

"If you really want to stop knowing... you can go back down. Can't you...?"

He knew it was a dead end. Yet he said it anyway, as if everything could still be sorted out without any pain. Very human. And that almost touched on the very reason for his visit.

Red simply replied, in a lower voice:

'It's not that simple.'

End of scene

Scene — Stagnant Youth Is No Major Asset

Agatha's residence — reception room, dusk

The light was fading. In the reception room, the air was still, almost motionless. Agatha stood without fanfare. Around her, Golbat, Arbok and Haunter occupied the space with a worn, dense presence. Nothing theatrical. Just the weight of age: restrained gestures, slow glances, a subtle senility that asked for nothing.

Agatha spoke first:

'Your formations are opulent, but far from excessive. My assistance would not be superfluous.'

Silence fell. She did not break it straight away.

"Pokémon grow old within their society, just as we do. This mutual support completes the collective. It requires no effort at all."

She continued after a moment:

'I excel in the Ghost type. But I haven't developed a philosophy as magnificent as some others. Morty, for example. It is my practice that sets me apart.'

Gold/Richter asked respectfully:

"Does your approach coincide with Koga's...? Like the Poison type...?"

"Koga excels at non-frontal combat. I excel at certain unconventional techniques. Not quite like Poison. More... devious, so to speak."

BGM 'Rebellion' 00:00–02:23

Gold/Richter offered a formal smile and enquired:

"What is the history between you and the professor...?"

Agatha looked away briefly.

"In his youth, he surpassed me in every way, including my tactics. Without arrogance. He knew that techniques cannot be separated from integrity and purpose. It took me a long time to accept that."

Gold/Richter pressed gently:

"But how did this turnaround come about?"

"My recurring complaint: he lavishes too much of his genius on science. Not out of pride. Out of duty, for society. In return, he weakens himself. Even his opponents barely know him. This omission compels others to gauge the cost... and to mature."

She made a brief gesture towards Arbok and Golbat.

"My specialism has brought me into contact with species that are, on the surface, more insidious, more calculating. As it happens, this suits your needs."

Gold/Richter lowered his eyes for a moment, then asked:

"Even if the young need not necessarily surpass their elders... why is it pernicious to pretend to remain young?"

Agatha replied without harshness:

"Their strengths exist only at their age. We no longer possess them. To still claim to be young betrays that one has retained only their flaws, without their advantages, and with nothing suitable to offer in their place."

A moment's pause.

"You have chosen an exceptional method. I believe you will be using these two species for this plan."

Gold/Richter nodded.

"...Yes. I've kept ethics in mind. I'll capture them with Friend Balls. Their autonomy will take precedence. I can't force them into it."

"Then my observations may be of use: their behaviour, their temperament. The things not recorded in the books."

Gold/Richter's eyes widened slightly.

Agatha continued, in a lower voice:

"Oak, Red and you: you work within the data, without becoming obsessed. You practise, you maintain your curiosity, you refuse to reduce everything to paper. If Oak has allowed me to use the rest of my time more sensibly... my experiences with these Pokémon will be precious assets. Even for you. Otherwise, old Oak's dedications would have been for nothing."

Gold/Richter paused to let the words sink in.

"...All right. Thank you. But why this sudden outburst? Neither I nor Red are really interested in the League. And are we even worthy of it...?"

Agatha:

“That lack of interest doesn’t mean you don’t respect us.

Oak did not wish to foster successors who would overshadow those of the past. He desired to pass on something more precious. Red confronted us reluctantly, yet without condescension or contempt. He could not avoid it. We saw that.

Old Oak made mistakes towards him and his grandson. Yes. But one cannot anticipate every mistake, even with the utmost care. His leadership is not entirely to blame.”

Gold/Richter said, in a lower voice:

‘...Yes. But some mistakes come at a price... one that is unacceptable for anyone.’

Agatha looked him straight in the eye.

“So not staying young serves as a remedy. To make it bearable. And so that the world doesn’t collapse.”

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment. Contained astonishment, without any desperate search for answers.

Agatha remained cool, calm, austere, confident, and subtly benevolent.

‘Consider my favour as a reward for old Oak. Thanks to him, his generation did not spend their time in vain.’

End of scene

Scene — Farewell to Childishness

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 3–4 hours*

Light snow was falling. The air was still. Red spoke first, almost to himself:

“But that doesn’t add up...”

He took out the Battle Searcher.

“My Battle Searcher never picked up a signal... How did you manage to slip past it in the meantime...?”

Gold/Richter looked as though he had crossed a line. He took out a more austere, purely functional device.

“...It was made by Professor Oak, on my instructions. It blocks the Battle Searcher’s detection. The Professor has also enhanced my Pokédex to collect data. And lifted the six-Pokémon limit.

I’ve investigated the levels of your Pokémon, their moves, their behaviour, and your coordination...”

Red took stock of the situation.

“How incredible... The Professor has granted you these exceptions... That’s not really like him. So he’s backing you to beat me?”

“Yes.”

Red continued, in a lower voice:

"You've secured this support, the equipment, the methods... You've disguised your Pokémon as wild ones... resorting to espionage. It's all far too meticulous for that to be the case..."

Gold/Richter's gaze took on a look of remorse, but something else was weighing on his mind.

Red asked, his voice neutral:

"You don't trust yourself that much...?"

"...One cannot deny your strength. In an asymmetrical situation, I'd be doomed to defeat..."

"But you know almost everything about me, whilst I know nothing about you... Is that symmetrical...?"

Gold/Richter seemed cornered for a moment:

"That is not cheating. The Gym Leaders, the Elite Four and the Champion all face the same conditions when facing challengers... Do they not? You, on the other hand, remain an enigma to everyone..."

BGM "EP04 S01 22:40–24:12"

"You're right," said Red. "But a clandestine hunt... that's rather controversial on an individual level."

"I'm responsible for my companions. I can't let them sacrifice themselves in vain."

"You cherish them, yet you force them into this..."

"...I've only got one chance. I'd have liked to avoid it, but I can't rely on them for this mission without it..."

'Is the loss weighing on you...?'

"You're strong. I'm aware of the discrepancy. Without information, without certain extras — even if they aren't really cheating — I can't catch up with you. I no longer have the resources or the time to reach your level..."

Red argued:

"...By acknowledging your limits, you're determined to become the strongest..."

"...I stopped wanting that a long time ago. I don't want it, even now."

'...Yet you must win...?'

"...Yes."

Gold/Richter sank into something abysmal, the nature of which Red could not yet perceive.

Red fell silent. He spoke more quietly:

"...I don't really hold it against you.

I did something similar... to thwart someone and secure a victory I did not want. So I see a connection. Although you go... further.

It simply makes me wonder... why the same story keeps repeating itself..."

Gold/Richter's eyes hardened, unbeknown to Red.

'This approach... I've been using it ever since I visited your house.'

Red listened more intently.

"Your bedroom remained almost untouched," said Gold/Richter. "Your past was there. But there was no trace of anything since you became a Trainer. I tried to dig deeper. Without success. I couldn't get to know you any better..."

Red was gradually struck by the realisation.

Gold/Richter continued:

BGM 'EP02 S02 15:20–16:20'

"When you became Champion... I was one of the children who looked up to you. I believed that love and friendship were enough to overcome anything. But since your misfortune, I was practically the only one whose heart was broken. Who was affected."

I've spent so much time trying to recover from it.

...I was chosen for the Pokédex by giving up the illusion of becoming the strongest. I simply wanted to investigate the causes of your imprecation... so that others might not fall victim to this tragedy.

I could not hide my admiration for you. I chose the Fire-type starter. Then I realised that the rivalry between Green and you was already a thing of the past. Blastoise versus Charizard... I did not have the courage to stick with my starter any longer."

A longer silence. He continued:

'...I only wanted to share your burdens. Even with my sincerity, I've always lived in your shadow... never truly worthy of being your successor. I couldn't escape the mistakes you made... nor avoid hurting those dear to me.'

Red, his voice heavy with suppressed guilt:

"So... you loathe me...? You hold me responsible for your misfortune..."

"...No. I'm frustrated that I know nothing about you."

The reply exceeded Red's expectations.

Gold/Richter continued, in an even quieter voice:

"Your feats are magnificent... and yet I don't really know you. Absolutely nothing. I've never met you in person. You're so admirable... and yet so distant at the same time."

He paused.

"The most macabre question... What sort of person have you become?"

When you have been isolated for so long, reduced to a scapegoat, after having taken it all on... what do you become? A cynic? Someone who looks down on others and despises the rest?

Beating someone like that would mean nothing. Even if I won. That is what I feared most."

Further down:

"It's not a subversive idea. Many people worry about it, I suppose. But I'm the only one who has to face it head-on.

My respect is sincere. My gratitude is too. But I can no longer admire you as others do. I can no longer be content with the illusion. I've had to cast aside my innocence and face it head-on. Irrevocably."

Red did not reply.

Only his gaze had taken on a contrite look.

End of scene

Scene — Shared Grief

Viridian — springtime daylight

The setting was crisp, spring-like, and yet somehow detached. The city was visible; only the conversation seemed truly present.

Lance was the first to smile. A bitter smile, but a human one.

'How wonderful that you're asking me this question...'

Gold/Richter lowered his eyes slightly. The shame was plain to see.

"I know this is a... mixed... request..."

He hesitated, then blurted out anyway:

"But what weaknesses... does Red have... to your knowledge...?"

He was already grappling with what he had just asked. Integrity and outrage were at odds.

"I'm not calling him an opportunist... But if I've simply taken on too many worries, never mind..."

BGM "EP 05 S02 01:20–02:48"

Lance initially pretended not to notice, maintaining a calculated calm. Just as Gold/Richter was about to withdraw, Lance spoke. The information was startling enough to freeze Gold/Richter in his tracks. Inaudible to anyone else.

Cut.

When the conversation resumed, Gold/Richter still could not believe what he had just heard.

Lance continued, calmly:

'That is to be expected. Under these conditions, he cannot mobilise his full strength... at the respective level.'

Gold/Richter, still in shock:

"How does that explain...? And is it appropriate for me to know this...?"

Lance looked him straight in the eye.

“You know the reasons for his weaknesses better than anyone. You’ve experienced them just like Red, occasionally even more so than he has. No doubt that’s what qualifies you more than your skill.”

Gold/Richter pondered this in silence. The emotional void he already carried—the one linked to Chris and Maria—rose silently within him.

Lance continued:

“I’m not urging you to exploit those weaknesses. But you deserve to learn about them... given that you’ve accepted this task.

And you’ll find a more discreet, fairer way... I hope.”

He remained impassive.

Gold/Richter’s look of shame had not yet faded.

End of scene

Scene — 15. Distant Proximity

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 3–4 hours*

Light snow was falling. The air was almost silent.

Gold/Richter spoke first:

‘Before we carry on...’

He threw a Ball. Skarmory emerged, clear and unobstructed.

“Can you reveal to me your deepest reason for staying here... if I am worthy of the truth...”

He was still feeling his way. Red hardly hesitated. Only the length of his reply held him back.

“...If the world were to collapse one day, or tomorrow... whose side would you want to be on?”

Gold/Richter was taken aback. One name, then another, flashed through his mind. Red sensed the connection. That was enough for him to continue.

BGM “EP05 S02 24:07–25:37”

“They call me a hero. A living legend,” said Red. “Like the Professor. I’ve succeeded him, in a way. But I’m still subject to certain desires. Like most people.”

A moment passed.

“I became Champion... or at least, I stopped Green in his folly. It wasn’t just down to me. I learnt from others. I followed in their footsteps.”

Gold/Richter, below:

‘You managed it... thanks to Misty’s feelings...’

Red lowered his gaze slightly.

“...In part. Indispensable. Hers. Those of others who were dear to me. My mother.

She told me: failure and success can both teach us something... if we're willing to look. They can also blind us.

I'd lost. Or I was allowed to lose... just like those I'd met along the way. Loss is only part of life. Not the whole of it. But since then... I've lost touch with something I shared with other people."

"Everyone is slightly different, aren't they?"

"Yes. But certain traits are crucial to remaining connected."

Gold/Richter hesitated.

'...You didn't really want to join the League... after Giovanni...?'

"...If I'd known I wouldn't be able to stop the end of the world, I would have stayed with those I cared about. They should have had my whole affection, not just bits and pieces.

I left, taking a huge gamble... that everything would be settled once and for all."

"...But it wasn't just Giovanni. Nor was it just Green...?"

"Certainly not. If they'd been the only problems, my decision would have been the right one."

A sense of foreboding washed over Gold/Richter.

Red continued:

"After Giovanni, Green, even Mewtwo... the enemies kept coming. It paralysed me. I wanted to believe that everything could still work out. That the gaps would be filled... if I stayed amongst my own.

I was wrong."

He raised a hand. He looked at it.

BGM "EP06 S01 09:00–09:58"

"...Suddenly, I saw an evil. A darkness... through red eyes."

Gold/Richter tried to picture it. Nothing clear. Just fragments.

"Eyes... so deep," said Red. "Transparent. Waxy. This evil isn't new. It goes back further. Perhaps before the dawn. It's there. Always.

I was too naive to see it. Or too reserved to recognise it. So my decision was a mistake."

Gold/Richter, very quietly:

"...So you hate Green for all this...?"

"I thought I hated him. It was an illusion. I hate myself. Or I fear myself. Or what I've become."

"But you're not a monster..."

"No. But am I human, then...?"

The question was not accusatory; it merely excluded any easy answer.

"I don't know which one I am," said Red. "What a joke. I realised Mewtwo's frustrations far too late."

He continued, his voice even more subdued:

BGM 'EP04 S01 18:10–18:47'

"The red eyes didn't really terrify me. They cornered me. There was no escape. They reminded me that I'd been wrong: if I stayed, people would forget what I'd become, what I'd lost, just like a human.

I was close. And hollow. Staying was not enough to make amends. Nor to offer what I had almost given.

Shame got the better of me. I shouldn't have defied Green. I should have stayed. I've only myself to blame."

Gold/Richter's eyes lost their sparkle.

Red suppressed a bitter smile, almost in spite of himself.

'To be perfectly honest, I would have liked to lose to you easily. For the sake of that right. But you wouldn't be able to bear it for long.

So I don't know whether I hold this position for the good of others... or whether I'm merely cloaking myself in moral superiority."

The smile was a mixture of sarcasm and melancholy. Then his expression grew steeper again.

'Do you intend to continue...?' Red asked.

End of scene

Scene — Heavenly Father

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 3–4 hours*

BGM 'Heavenly Father' 01:51– 04:03

The snow had the consistency of mud. Their footprints remained blurred, barely etched into it. The air hung heavy. One felt suffocated just by looking.

Their gazes had frozen. Pokémon. Trainers. Nothing had yet begun, and already everything felt heavy.

BGM 'Heavenly Father' 02:17–

Gold/Richter traced a rudimentary route in the air, clear enough to be read. Skarmory took off. Mediocre speed. It veered off without really getting far.

Red made a hand signal. Lapras received it with half-hearted attention and unleashed Ice Beam. The first shot missed. The rest found their mark. Hit.

Skarmory had not anticipated this. It fired back an Icy Wind. The damage to Lapras was negligible. The intention, however, was clear: to slow it down.

Another Ice Beam. Skarmory landed. Roost. The Flying-type froze in mid-air. The ice beam penetrated more deeply than expected, but the body straightened up. Then Icy Wind again, to weigh it down.

BGM 'Heavenly Father' 02:40

Red's alternating moves. Hydro Pump. The column of water grazed Skarmory, rubbing against it and reducing the damage.

Skarmory unleashed Metal Sound and gained altitude, already preparing for another Roost. The metal cut through the air, rasping, relentless.

Red and Lapras then devised a tactic: Skarmory was not attacking; it was sabotaging.

Ice Beam. Skarmory realised it could not dodge. It threw itself into the snow, Roost. The beam passed. The sound returned.

BGM 'Heavenly Father' 03:04

Red absorbed the after-effects. Something clicked inside him. His next move was even more unfathomable.

Hydro Pump. Skarmory landed from below, using Roost once more.

Then Lapras sang.

BGM 'Heavenly Father' 03:27

Perish Song.

The atmosphere took on a different hue. Funerary. Almost liturgical. Skarmory and Gold/Richter were struck by this impassivity. The pressure thickened, palpable, without a sound.

Ice Beam struck again. Gold/Richter stood dumbfounded. Skarmory took the initiative, fearing it might be too late. The damage was contained. The anxiety, however, was not.

They held their ground. Recalling too soon would have given away the advantage. Gold/Richter brooded. Red remained serene, as if the countdown did not affect Lapras.

Gold/Richter saw the potential trap: a Fire Spin upon recall, Skarmory caught in the light, sacrificed for nothing. Or something else. Same result.

Background music: 'Heavenly Father' 03:50–04:03

He raised his hand.

The Ball nestled between three fingers.

Shortly afterwards, Red recalled Lapras.

Almost in unison, they summoned them. Venusaur. Fearow.

Fearow still had some Agility left; the paralysis was helping it to recover from some of its mid-air stumbles.

A few seconds.

Gold/Richter broke the silence:

'By the way... I've been wondering for a while... why you've not just got Charizard, but also a Venusaur. It doesn't quite add up...'

Red was overcome by a brief, warm wave of nostalgia.

"It's not quite mine..."

Gold/Richter gazed into the icy air.

End of scene

Scene — The Continual Journey

Pallet Town — spring daylight

BGM "EP03 S02 25:00–26:30"

The setting was bright, almost too bright. You could see the houses, the grass, the low-hanging sky. Only the conversation seemed to be truly present.

Red was holding the Venusaur Ball. He had not clenched it yet.

'You don't need your partner anymore...?'

Blue replied bluntly:

"Yes. But you've decided to leave. You don't really know the other Grass-type Pokémon. Venusaur will be the best option."

Red hesitated. The discomfort of taking that on board was palpable.

Blue added:

"I did not lend it to you when you challenged Misty. There you go. A token of compensation."

Red still had not grasped the true intention behind it.

Blue lowered her voice slightly.

"I wanted you to be happy, at last. But two wishes are too many to grant... on the face of it."

A silence.

"You kept your word," she said. "As for me, I played a part in your setback."

This cast a shadow over Red. He could not bring himself to blame her.

"I cannot take away your sorrow. Nor can I share it. At least I can soothe it in this way. I hope," she said.

Red asked, more quietly:

"You need your partner, but without loving them...?"

"Enough. My journey has ended. Yours continues."

It touched him, just a little.

Blue continued:

"In any case, you wouldn't want to take a hit from Green's Blastoise..."

A strange sensation washed over Red. No loathing. Just bitter, unpleasant memories.

She confided in him:

“On that note, Keep it.”

BGM ‘EP07 S01 09:50–10:35’

Red ceased to resist. He clutched the Ball close to his body.

Blue looked at him again.

“Misty’s badge will stay with you. Your heart will remain with her, wherever you go, wherever you are. But that certainly would not be enough to bring you back.”

After a longer pause, she continued:

“I’m lending it to you. I’m not giving it to you. I want to see it again one day. And I want you to give it back to me.”

Red took in her expression. He understood.

Blue concluded, almost without solemnity:

“...Consider this my blessing. To you. To Misty. That you may return to us. And to her.”

End of scene

Scene — The Wager or the Ethic

Mt. Silver — *high-altitude slopes, 3–4 hours*

BGM ‘Always’ 00:32–

Enhanced Beat 1 — 00:32 → 00:55

The snow was patchy. It no longer covered everything. In places, the earth oozed, dark, like ancient mud. The wind had no voice. It merely shifted what was already there.

Nothing had yet set in motion. Yet the air had thickened, clinging to eyelids and wrists. You could feel it in your throat before you saw it.

Venusaur barely moved. Its bulk stood out against the worn-out white. A brief puff of vapour with every breath. Fearow, for his part, held the air out of habit — and the paralysis was already reminding him that habit was no longer enough. One wing lagged behind. A recovery that was too abrupt.

Gold/Richter was not looking at Red. He was looking at the interval. His fingers fell into position, seemingly calm. A tiny wobble at the tip of the finger, quickly corrected.

Red did not raise his hands. Just a single movement, barely a gesture. Venusaur registered it as one registers a sentence already known.

Between them, the snow continued to fall lightly enough that one could hear the crystals striking the feathers, the skin, the ground. Each impact was too small. The sum of them was not.

Gold/Richter took a breath. The air stung slightly, cold and dirty. Fearow tilted its head. Not the order yet. Only the certainty that the order would come too soon, or too late.

BGM 'Always' 00:55–

Fearow moved away from its original position.

Venusaur scattered Sleep Powder in its direction. Fearow dodged it easily, then reflected the move back with Mirror Move. The headwind scattered the powder. Little effect.

Leech Seed followed, uneventfully. Fearow took precautions nonetheless.

Almost in the same breath, Sludge Bomb pierced through the reflected Sleep Powder. Fearow suffered a bout of paralysis and flew off at an angle. A few stray feathers remained soiled.

Time was running out for Gold/Richter. A sense of bitterness. Then a decision. A resolute gesture.

BGM 'Always' 01:20–

Fearow deflected the Sludge Bomb with Mirror Move. The aim was slightly off. The force was weak. By a hair's breadth: one of Venusaur's feet was soiled, but no tangible damage was done.

A diversion. Fearow had already picked up speed. Aerial Ace struck without restraint, ferocious against the Grass-type — painful, but the distress remained moderate: the difference in levels, the mediocre power of the blow.

BGM 'Always' 01:34 -

On the second Aerial Ace, paralysis threw it off course slightly. That was not the only reason.

Gold/Richter realised too late: Venusaur had slipped in Giga Drain, evening out the damage. Red had not moved. Everything was going according to plan. Hooked.

Gold/Richter flinched. Fearow abandoned the assault and wheeled away. The paralysis permitted Venusaur to plant Leech Seed almost unopposed.

The seeds took hold. Fearow was already limping through the air. Gold/Richter panicked.

BGM 'Always' 01:47–the end

Red remained detached, observant, not sadistic.

Gold/Richter was under double pressure. Fearow was weary, on the verge of exhaustion.

Should he sacrifice one last move — or withdraw, so as not to leave it drained and paralysed in vain?

Gold/Richter hesitated no longer. With a heavy heart, he raised his hand.

The Ball absorbed Fearow and returned to the palm of his hand, feeling heavier than usual.

Gold/Richter closed his eyes. A brief penance.

The end of the BGM

A silence lasting a few seconds.

Red asked, without any edge to his voice:

'Weren't you going to push through that last bit of resistance...?'

Gold/Richter still clutched the Ball. His gaze was contrite — a lack of skill, or of resolve.

“...Not at all,” said Gold/Richter. “It was too much of a moral burden for me...”

Red blinked. No accusation:

“...No worries. It’s not a sign of weakness...”

Gold/Richter continued to feel his helplessness.

End of scene

Scene — Vivaldi’s Four Seasons: Summer (L’Estate) presto

Mt. Silver — *high slopes, 3–4 hours*

BGM: ‘Vivaldi’s Four Seasons: Summer (L’Estate) presto’ in EP02 07 S01 of Castlevania: Nocturne

Gold/Richter tucked the Fearow Ball away against his side, inside his jacket. He produced another one. Fairness. From that distance, Red could only make out its shape.

The throw was made without haste, without any apparent calculation. Alakazam emerged.

Red and Venusaur recognised the disadvantage at once: C, Spe. Red considered recalling it.

Too late.

Psychic was unleashed, spontaneous, disciplined, with almost no movement from Gold/Richter. Venusaur buckled under significant damage. Red recalled it. The Ball returned to his palm. He contemplated: nearly exhausted.

A flash: Espeon, back then, against Giovanni’s Nidoking. The same pattern—more hasty, more calculated back then. A fleeting smile crossed Red’s face. Awe, despite Gold/Richter’s youth.

He threw another Poké Ball. Espeon appeared.

Gold/Richter and Alakazam both stepped up their vigilance.

Gold/Richter made a more complex gesture: not the numerical code for a move, but a rudimentary manoeuvre. Alakazam fired Psychic at Espeon — the instantaneous, type-based attack, yet delivered with restraint. The damage was manageable. Painful, given the sheer power.

Espeon responded with a lightly charged Shadow Ball. The visible impact remained limited. Alakazam did not dare to underestimate it: Espeon’s Sp. Atk. It dodged it without too much trouble. The missed strike fizzled out in the piled-up snow, held back by Espeon.

Espeon read the rest of Red’s move. Not just a single move. A pattern.

A second Shadow Ball, of the same intensity. It missed.

As Alakazam circled, Espeon had already closed the distance. Quick Attack. A third Shadow Ball was being charged.

Dodging was becoming a dead end. Gold/Richter made a gesture of anguish — Alakazam was clearly uncomfortable seeing him like this.

Teleport.

Espeon and Red were taken by surprise: that move was reserved for just such an occasion.

A momentary side effect. His concentration wavered.

Espeon unleashed Psychic, in that split second, to relieve the burden. The effect was mixed. Enough to weigh down the aftermath of Teleport.

Quick Attack again. This time, Shadow Ball was charged. Stable range. Accuracy. Espeon's C-rank excellence, a slight difference in level. Alakazam did not survive it.

It collapsed into the snow-covered ground. The snow engulfed it.

Gold/Richter watched. The deficit was not to be underestimated. He resigned himself to it. He raised his hand. The Ball returned.

'So... that's why Mewtwo lost to you...'

The conjecture hung in the air. It was not a question.

End of scene

Scene — The Controversial Choice

Mt Silver — *high slopes, 3–4 hours*

BGM: 'Annette's Journey' 01:05–01:40

Red and Espeon were still holding their own. Almost at ease. The last battle had ended in the snow.

For Gold/Richter, it was not a disadvantage. It was a choice, almost inevitable.

He took out a Ball. He looked at it. His thumb lingered too long on the seam. A moment's hesitation. A pang of guilt. Not a breakdown: just the time it took to accept what was coming. Espeon barely turned its ear towards him, not towards Red.

BGM: 'Annette's Journey' 01:22 –

The uncertainty faded. An unusual lull. He resigned himself to it.

He projected.

The Pokémon appeared in the snow. At first, a mass. A silhouette. Not a name.

Red and Espeon were terrified by the presence.

The footprints were fresh, too distinct in the slushy snow. Pads. Claws. Between the tracks, a gap that was too still.

BGM: "EP03 S02 24:40–25:00"

Red was struck deeper than after Psychic. Older memories. The bark. That one. The body remembered before the species.

Its breath was visible. Streams of vapour rising from its muzzle. Its nose, black, precise. An irregular mist, too slow for the tension.

Red's eyes asked, without a sound: why was Gold/Richter taming such a macabre Pokémon, one that so few could tame?

Gold/Richter lowered his gaze to the snow-covered ground. No shame. He imagined Red's doubts, though not in full. Only in silence: this choice did him no favours.

Red resigned himself to the decision.

BGM "EP03 S02 24:40–25:00" 00:11–the end

The body came into view in stages, from bottom to top. Paws. Chest. Horns. Muzzle. Houndoom.

A lingering sense of horror washed over Red. It was not the *creature's* nature. It was the image: the infernal bark, always on the verge of happening.

Houndoom stood still. It simply was there. Vampire. Guardian. Creature of the night. A form of blackmail by the station alone.

We waited for the bark. A second. Another. Imminent.

It never came.

End of episode

Close of episode

Totals

≈ 11,100 words · 35 pp. A4 · read aloud ≈ 75 min.

Pass 1/3 — still open

Gold/Richter only. lowered / daze / withdrew. Blue = key. OST titles out of headings. Screen notes out of the body. Notes moved here. P1: Night-time → Nocturnal Day; creations → compilations; disabuse → defeat; curse → imprecation (×3); Blue his → her; hold him back → Hold it; Childhood → Childishness; Never-Ending → Continual; gamble or ethics → Wager or the Ethic.

Version notes

2026-09-24 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. Vivaldi = external. Traces = address. Author filled. Title: The Flame Tempered by Water. Two Lances kept distinct. Blue ≠ Green.

Open for what follows

Houndoom in the snow · Venusaur / Blue · Red still there.

BGM credits

Nocturne pieces: Trevor Morris & Trey Toy. Vivaldi via the series. Traces: duration only.